

Where do I start?

If you're confident that your financial situation is ready for homeownership, then the process starts with finding an agent and a lender. From there, you'll pursue loan preapproval, which will act as your ticket to making an offer on a house. (This is obviously an oversimplification. We did just write a whole book about this process, after all.)

Can I actually afford the amount I'm preapproved for?

Technically, yes. Your lender wouldn't offer you a loan you can't afford; otherwise you would be a liability.

In our opinion, though, you should determine what you can afford prior to reaching out to lenders. Consider what you're willing to pay monthly toward housing, and factor that into your other monthly costs. We could write a whole separate book on personal finance (in fact, Scott already did—it's called *Set for Life*), but the gist is that you should consider your own comfort level more important than the number your lender gives you.

As a married couple, is it better for just one or both of us to be on the loan?

There are many factors to consider, but the bottom line is that you can apply for more mortgages if you split up ownership—say, if you're interested in financing multiple properties with FHA loans. However, if something happens to one of the spouses, the remaining spouse may be required to refinance the loan or sell the property in the deceased spouse's name.

If you're unsure which option is better, talk to your lender during the preapproval process and they can break down what both options would look like. You might not be able to qualify for as much on one person's income, but it could be a better option if one person's credit score is lacking.

How long does it take to buy a home?

Another huge oversimplification, but home shopping will take at least thirty to forty-five days and closing will take another thirty to forty-five days. However, don't limit your timeline for buying a house—refer to Chapter Five if you need a refresher on why this is a terrible idea.

How does my agent get paid?